Acceptable use of IT equipment

Article KB0010089 | Owner: Security Operations | Subcategory: General | Applies to: Windows 11 laptops (Dell Latitude 5440/7440, Lenovo ThinkPad T14/X1 Carbon, HP EliteBook 840), macOS 14/15 MacBook Pro/Air, Company-issued smartphones and tablets, Desktop workstations, VPN, Wi-Fi (ACME-Corp, ACME-Guest), Microsoft 365 services (Outlook, Teams, OneDrive, SharePoint)

Summary

This article outlines Acme Global's Acceptable Use Policy for IT equipment, describing what constitutes appropriate and inappropriate use of company-owned laptops, desktops, mobile devices, network resources, and cloud services. It provides users with a self-help checklist to verify compliance, explains how to report concerns, and gives Service Desk agents a clear procedure for handling policy violations and escalating to Security Operations.

Symptoms

- Receipt of a pop-up warning or email from the Security Operations team indicating a policy violation
- Inability to access certain applications or websites due to content filtering
- Account lockout or MFA prompts triggered by suspicious activity
- Notification from PaperCut or VPN logs showing unauthorized usage

Common causes

- Using company equipment for personal commercial activities, gambling, or illegal downloads
- Sharing credentials or bypassing MFA controls
- Attempting to install unapproved software or modify system settings
- Accessing prohibited websites or transmitting sensitive data outside approved channels
- Storing personal data on company devices without encryption

Policy Overview

Acme Global expects all employees, contractors, and guests to use IT equipment solely for legitimate business purposes. Acceptable use includes performing job-related tasks, accessing approved corporate applications, communicating via Outlook and Teams, and using the VPN or Wi-Fi for secure remote work. Incidental personal use such as checking personal email during breaks is permitted provided it does not interfere with work, consume excessive bandwidth, or violate security controls. Any activity that could compromise confidentiality, integrity, or availability of company information-or that violates local laws-is prohibited.

Self-Help Procedure: Ensuring Acceptable Use

Follow these steps to confirm that your use of Acme IT resources remains within policy limits. If you are unsure about a specific action, consult the full Acceptable Use Policy on the intranet or contact the Service Desk for clarification.

1. Review the list of approved applications in Company Portal before installing any software.
2. Verify that you are connected to the ACME-Corp Wi-Fi or VPN when accessing internal systems; avoid using ACME-Guest for confidential work.
3. Do not share your password, PIN, or MFA approvals with anyone; use the self-service password reset portal if you forget credentials.
4. Refrain from downloading or streaming copyrighted media, gambling sites, or any content flagged by web filters.
5. If you need to store personal files temporarily, encrypt them using BitLocker (Windows) or FileVault (Mac) and delete them as soon as the task is complete.

Verification and Reporting

Users should periodically check that their device complies with encryption and patching requirements. Open the Company Portal app to confirm that the device is compliant and that BitLocker/FileVault status shows 'Protected'. Review recent sign-in activity in the My Sign-ins page of Microsoft Entra ID to spot unfamiliar locations. If you observe any warning messages, suspect misuse, or receive a policy-violation notice, report it immediately through the IT Help Teams channel or by calling extension 4357 (HELP). Including screenshots, timestamps, and a brief description helps Security Operations investigate quickly.

Service Desk Procedure

When a user reports a potential acceptable-use issue or when automated alerts (Defender for Endpoint, PaperCut, VPN logs) indicate a violation, follow the steps below to gather information, provide initial guidance, and escalate as needed. Document all interactions in the ticket and tag the Security Operations group for further review.

1. Create a ticket in the Service Desk system, selecting the 'Security - Acceptable Use' category and setting the initial priority to P3 (Moderate).
2. Ask the user to describe the activity that triggered the alert, collect any error messages, and request screenshots if available.
3. Check the device compliance status in Intune (encryption, patch level, installed applications) and review recent sign-in logs in Entra ID for anomalies.
4. If the activity is clearly prohibited (e.g., illegal downloads, credential sharing), advise the user to cease the behavior immediately and remind them of the policy.
5. For ambiguous cases or repeated incidents, escalate the ticket to the Security Operations team, providing the ticket ID, user name, device ID, summary of findings, and any collected evidence.

When to escalate

Escalate to the Security Operations group when: (a) the user confirms or evidence shows deliberate violation of the Acceptable Use Policy (e.g., illegal downloading, credential sharing, attempts to bypass MFA); (b) the incident involves potential data loss, exposure of confidential information, or regulatory concerns; or (c) the user repeats the behavior after initial remediation. Include in the escalation: ticket number, user name and employee ID, device hostname and serial number, a concise description of the violation, relevant logs (Intune compliance, Entra ID sign-ins, Defender alerts, PaperCut or VPN logs), and any screenshots or statements gathered by the Service Desk.

Keywords: acceptable use, AUP, IT equipment policy, personal use, prohibited activity, security violation, policy compliance, report misuse, security operations, service desk procedure